ruling foundation of the Party’.

~

As we have seen, the Xi Jinping era is different in many respects from the Deng era of Reform and Opening-Up. However, as mentioned earlier, for the Party the constant has been survival of the one-party Leninist state. If Deng believed that Reform and Opening-Up, and allowing the private sector to flourish, was necessary for the Party to survive, Xi Jinping is grappling with the inevitable diffusion of power and the spread of new attitudes among a rising and educated middle class which questions Party orthodoxy and its claim to overweening power. Exposure to the outside world and constant engagement with it makes it difficult for a nation to sustain ideological purity. Nothing is more feared than ‘regime change’ or a ‘colour’ revolution, which may change the very character of the socialist state. The Party may lose its legitimacy through corruption. It may be ideologically disarmed by the allure of liberal democracy. It may lose its monopoly of political power to notions of multiparty competitive politics.

The third Party History Resolution reaffirms the Reform and Opening-Up Policy, but also points to the adverse consequences of the strategy, especially in terms of maintaining the undisputed authority of the Party. It is indeed difficult to see how the Party’s singular hold on power can be reconciled with an open-door policy.

For a one-party Leninist state, the interests of the Party would clearly have priority over economic reforms. If an economic policy which may deliver significant benefits were to threaten the authority of the Party, it would not be countenanced. The inward turn in Xi Jinping’s policies is driven by this preoccupation.

The Chinese economy is now on a slower growth trajectory. This is inevitable. Economic history tells us that economies having traversed a high-growth phase usually come down to a longer-term GDP growth rate of 2–3 per cent per annum as they begin to mature. China is unlikely to be an exception to this trend. An important source of the CPC’s political legitimacy over the past four decades has been its ability to deliver